

Off the Shelf



Microsoft Flight Simulator 2004: A Century of Flight

Flights of Fancy

The developers of the game have gone to great lengths to recreate the look and feel of a real aircraft. It starts with a brief overview of some important controls and manoeuvres in the form of videos. Then you get a training lesson from an irritating instructor in a Cessna 172B. Once you've got that pilot's license, it's on to commercial jets.

The effects are sensational with a high level of realism. If you take off in a blizzard, and forget to de-ice your wings in the pre-flight check, prepare for sluggish handling and a difficult flight. Even airports and cities are well detailed, with realistic landmarks.



Gosh, they even placed a pilot in the cockpit. How cool is that!

You can choose to fly any plane made in the last 100 years, from the Kitty Hawk (the Wright brothers' first flying machine)

to ultra-modern super jets and even the Robinson R22 II helicopter. Unfortunately, planes made in Europe such as the Concorde and the Airbus A340 are omitted.

There are two single player modes: one where you go on historic flights, and another where you choose your plane, weather conditions, flight path, etc. Though you can play this game with a keyboard, a joystick is almost essential. This isn't a combat simulator, so unless you like circling an airport while others try their best to land or crash, the multi-player mode is pretty useless. Overall, it's only the price tag that kills the fun.

Genre: Simulation ■ **Developer:** Microsoft Game Studios ■ **Publisher:** Microsoft Game Studios ■ **Distributor:** Sujata Softech ■ **System Requirements:** 450 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 1.8 GB disk space, DirectX 9 ■ **Price:** Rs 3,495 ■ **Web site:** www.microsoft.com/games/flightsimulator
Rating: ★★★★★

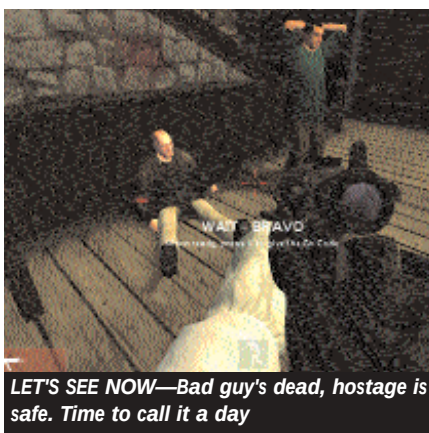


Rainbow Six 3: Raven Shield

Die another way

Another excellent team shooter! *Rainbow Six 3: Raven Shield* takes the art of squad-based tactical combat and bundles it with the Unreal engine. It starts with a briefing on a terrorist situation, and then you have to choose your men, the equipment they'll use, and go through a planning screen. You move slowly through the level, gauge the threat situation, locate the terrorists and be very very careful. Needless to say, you die a lot, as a single bullet kills and terrorists are trigger happy, both with you and the hostages.

There have been substantial improvements in the HUD and command system. The new Fluid Motion function allows you to take complete control of every movement—you don't have to peek com-



LET'S SEE NOW—Bad guy's dead, hostage is safe. Time to call it a day

pletely around a corner. Instead, you can gradually ease your head around it and

stay out of the enemy's firing line.

The AI has also been improved tremendously. The enemy is also more aggressive, and can respond to both sound and sight. Your team is also helped by the new AI—spin around and you'll see each member of your team pointing in different directions, like they should.

The only disappointment in the graphics are the vehicles; everything else is greatly improved. The sound is also great, except for the monotony of the accents. The biggest disappointment is the multi-player LAN restriction. Overall, it's a great game, and with the innumerable mods available online, there's never going to be a dull moment.

Courtesy SkOAR!

Genre: Tactical Shooter ■ **Developer:** Red Storm Entertainment ■ **Publisher:** Ubi Soft Entertainment ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive
System requirements: 800 MHz CPU, 256 MB RAM, 32 MB 3D video card ■ **Price:** Rs 920 ■ **Web site:** www.raven-shield.com
Rating: ★★★★★